

Saudization is a *capability* strategy.

A point of view for human capital leaders on workforce nationalisation as competitive advantage, not compliance.

THE ARGUMENT

A quota is a floor, not a strategy.

The banking sector has already proved the ceiling is high.

Localisation in Saudi banking has topped 94 per cent, and 88 per cent across the wider finance sector. Nationalisation at that depth was not achieved by quota compliance. It was achieved by institutions that built pipelines, career paths and succession plans for Saudi talent.

The demography is the opportunity. Over 60 per cent of the

Kingdom's population is under 30, and Nitaqat has directed hundreds of thousands of private-sector roles toward Saudi nationals. The question for a financial institution is not whether to nationalise. It is whether it gets the most capable share of a young, ambitious talent pool, or the remainder.

Rigour makes it bankable. Workforce decisions carry real money.

In one NBF1 merger, a granular HR synergy model validated SAR 4.75M in annual savings across three scenarios — with the rigour to secure both Board approval and SAMA regulatory sign-off. Saudization done at that standard is not a cost line. It is a capability plan the Board can underwrite.

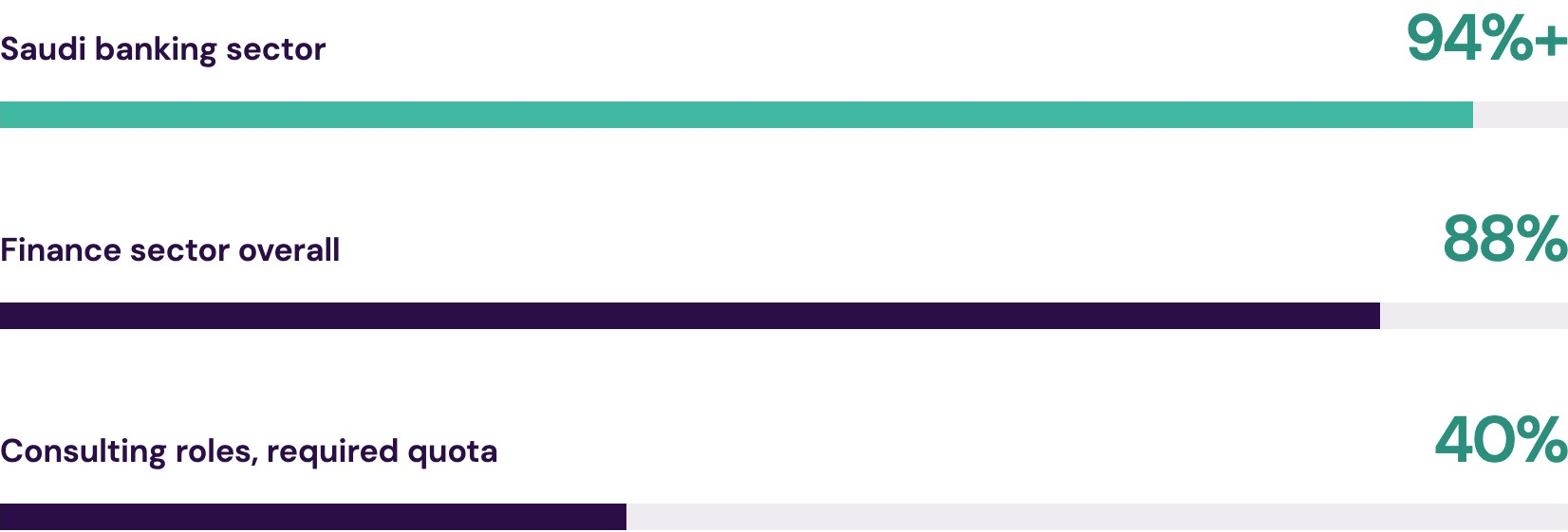
Why the institutions that treat nationalisation as workforce design will out-hire, out-retain and out-perform those that treat it as compliance.

*“The institutions that win will hire the Kingdom's best, **not the quota's remainder.**”*

THE EVIDENCE

How far nationalisation has *come*.

LOCALISATION BY SECTOR



THE FORCES BEHIND THE NUMBERS

60%+

of the Kingdom's population is under 30 — the deepest young talent pool in the region.

340,000

private-sector jobs targeted for Saudi nationals under the Nitaqat programme.

6 tiers

Nitaqat's classification bands, from Platinum to Red — compliance now shapes an institution's licence to hire at all.

Sources: Saudi Ministry of Human Resources and Social Development statements on finance and banking localisation; Nitaqat programme documentation; Saudi Vision 2030. Aspiro analysis.

THE FRAMEWORK

From quota to *capability*: four shifts.

01

Skills mapping before headcount

Map the capabilities the strategy needs, then design Saudi talent pipelines toward them — not toward whatever roles are easiest to fill.

03

Careers, not positions

Retention follows progression: succession plans and leadership paths that make the institution the destination for the Kingdom's best.

02

Transitions managed with care

Workforce transition handled as the human process it is: knowledge transfer planned, departures dignified, capability preserved through the change.

04

Numbers a Board can underwrite

Scenario-based workforce models with validated savings and regulatory-grade rigour — the standard SAMA approval demands.





CASE STUDY

Workforce numbers that survived *regulatory* scrutiny.

SAR 4.75M

ANNUAL RECURRING HR SYNERGIES

HR synergy realisation — NBFi merger

A Saudi non-bank financial institution merger, under SAMA supervision.

THE CHALLENGE

A merger requiring workforce consolidation with credible synergy numbers — under Board scrutiny and SAMA regulatory review, in a market where Saudization obligations shape every people decision.

WHAT WE DID

Built a granular HR synergy model across three scenarios: role-by-role mapping, transition planning and validated savings, designed to hold up to regulatory examination.

THE OUTCOME

SAR 4.75M in validated annual recurring savings with a 6 to 12 month payback — approved by the Board and signed off by SAMA.

SAR 4.75M

Annual recurring HR synergies

3

Scenarios modelled and validated

6–12mo

Payback, with Board and SAMA approval



WHAT TO DO ON MONDAY

Four moves before the next Nitaqat *review*.

01

Audit skills, not just numbers

Where the strategy needs capability, and where Saudi talent can reach it fastest.

02

Build the pipeline early

Graduate intakes, secondments and training mapped to the roles that matter, years ahead of need.

03

Model the money

Scenario-based workforce economics, validated to the standard a Board and SAMA will accept.

04

Make retention the metric

Hiring to quota is easy. Keeping the Kingdom's best is the measure that compounds.

Leading with clarity.
Delivering the *difference*.

Start a conversation

ABOUT ASPIRO

Aspiro is an independent, investor-free management consultancy for GCC financial institutions, founded in Dubai in 2015 with offices in Riyadh and London. Its partners carry 100+ years of senior leadership experience, backed by a network of 8,000+ specialists.

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